

VENDAKKAI MANDI, TAMIL NADU

Zacharias spent part of his trip to Tamil Nadu at Karaikudi, where he spent a day learning how to cook Chettinad food from the chef at The Bangala heritage homestay. He remembers one dish—*Vendakkai mandi*—particularly well. "It has bhindi, shallots, cloves of garlic, mustard and curry leaves. What really makes it special is that the bhindi is soaked in *mandi*, starch water left from soaking rice, which is then added to the curry. The starch allows it to thicken," he says. "Most associate Chettinad cuisine with meat-heavy preparations, but it has some fantastic vegetarian food."

KHEEMA, LUCKNOW

Zacharias' favourite restaurant in Lucknow is one he discovered by accident. It's a place in Alamgir that offers food cooked in the *bara handi* style: slow cooking different cuts of meat in 12 vessels. "The kheema there was rich and satisfying. It was prepared simply, with garlic, green chillies and ghee and barely any masala. It had so much ghee!" he says, adding that he even carried some back to Mumbai to share with others.

MISHING MEAL, ASSAM

In a house built on a stilt on the island of Majuli in Assam, Zacharias had what he described as one of his favourite meals ever—Borasaul sticky rice, *patodia maach* (marinated holmaas wrapped in a banana leaf and buried under smoldering wooden planks), *pura mangsho* (country chicken cooked on wooden skewers near an open flame), *singha diya mangsho* (marinated pork stuffed in bamboo and cooked over fire), a stir-fry of fiddlehead ferns and a Mishing fish curry with *bhut* (local ridge gourd). "I learned a lot about their cuisine. They use an open wood fire to cook. Fermentation and sun-drying are important to preserve their food," he says.

PATRA PODA, ODISHA



The dish stood out because it was simple to make and used pumpkin leaves, which are rarely eaten anymore. "Patra Poda has chicken, prawns, mushrooms, greens or tiny fish, which are mixed in a paste of black mustard, cumin, green chillies and garlic. This is then wrapped in pumpkin/poi saag leaves and roasted on an open fire till charred," says Zacharias. "You find leaf-wrapped food across the country, but here, you can eat the leaves as well." Zacharias recreated the Chingudi (prawn) Patra Poda at TBC, and shared the recipe on his channel too.

SUNDARKALA, UTTARAKHAND

"Sundarkala are hand-rolled, long and thick whole wheat noodles, flavoured with turmeric powder. They are tossed in green chilli, garlic leaves and *faran* [a herb from the onion family]," says Zacharias. He likens it to penne tossed in dry pesto. "I loved the fact that we have such interesting pasta in India." Sunderkala originates in Chamoli district of Uttarakhand, and likely has Tibetan roots. Zacharias learned how to make it from a family in Dehradun. "As I ate it, I kept thinking of the applications it could have as a restaurant dish," he says.